

Who was I with before, during, or after I made the purchase?
Where was I coming from or on my way to when I made the purchase?
What was going on or what was I doing right before I bought this?
How was I feeling before or after I made this purchase?
Was I trying to fulfill a value by making this purchase?
Did it give me the result that I wanted?

You don't have to answer all those questions for every purchase; they're just examples to jog your memory. This is an unbiased exercise in learning more about what causes you to spend money. By exploring each expense, you start to see which purchases could most easily be eliminated, which ones are currently aligned with your values, and if there are any environmental changes you can make to avoid some spending. You also learn more about who you are and why you spend what you spend, which will ultimately lead to greater understanding of your values.

Don't expect to be able to do this all in an hour or try to rush through it. Give the glorious 90-day transaction inventory the time it deserves. But don't overthink it either. If the idea of a transaction inventory feels overwhelming, try tackling a month at a time and finish it over three days. Don't feel embarrassed or like you're not normal if this takes you longer to complete than you thought it would. This isn't a test, there are no right answers, and you are not required to submit a response for every transaction. But—spoiler alert—we'll be referencing it a lot moving forward, so it is important to try.

Muffin Moment

You might look at your transaction inventory and think, "I love too much, I just need to earn more." Again, income is important. We don't want to minimize the significance of earning an amount of money that meets both your needs and your desires. But if you don't know *how* to spend it, earning more of it won't solve your problems or get you closer to the things you love. It may even create more problems, like it did for our friends Haley and Justin. At twenty-four years old, after his grandma died of mesothelioma, Justin received a \$600,000 wrongful death lawsuit payout. Haley and Justin both grew up in lower-income single-mom households in